

Chapter 89_1 - Demon Lord

No wonder in her previous life, apart from her mother and close friends, no one treated her well. No wonder every person she encountered despised her to such an extent. No wonder those who treated her kindly all died tragically.

It turned out that those who called her a cursed child were all correct—she truly was born a calamity.

Ning Changfeng, if only you had told me all this back then, I would have definitely ended my own life rather than bring disaster upon you all.

"Ning Fuyi." Nine Infants saw her shattered expression and couldn't help but become anxious, reaching out to turn her shoulders toward herself. "Don't let your thoughts run wild. There are clearly many people who treat you well. When I first met you, I never felt any disgust toward you. Perhaps this so-called curse is just a deception and has no effect on you?"

Ning Fuyi didn't meet her gaze, only said softly: "It has no effect now only because the curse has been broken."

"Then that's settled. Since this curse is gone, you shouldn't torment yourself over it anymore. There's nothing in this world that can't be overcome. When you live for hundreds or thousands of years like me in the future, all these sufferings will be nothing."

Nine Infants squeezed her shoulders comfortingly. "If you feel pain in your heart, then cry more." She tried to make her laugh. "Remember to take out your Divine Venerable—these tears mustn't be wasted."

Ning Fuyi indeed smiled through her tears and shook her head: "I'm just too shocked, not in pain."

"Actually, I never felt that Ning Changfeng loved me in the past. Compared to other mothers, she really wasn't like a mother at all—she wouldn't return home more than a few times a year. The reason I missed her was only because she was my only relative in this world."

"But now I know how much she did for me in secret, how she used her life to protect mine and keep me alive."

"It turns out I was once loved like this. Just thinking about it makes all the pain disappear."

Ning Fuyi placed the box in her hands on the table, gently closing it, and wiped away her tears with her sleeve: "Chu Qingqiu let me see all this to make me understand everything Ning Changfeng did, so I wouldn't let down her efforts."

"She really is..." Ning Fuyi smiled with meaningful ambiguity. "Full of thoughtfulness."

Nine Infants looked at this fragile, tearful Ning Fuyi and spread her arms wide, making an expression of throwing caution to the wind: "Alright, since you don't feel pain, then I won't worry either. This divine beast will condescend to let you embrace me today, as comfort."

She was originally joking, but Ning Fuyi suddenly stepped forward and hugged her tightly. Nine Infants was stunned for a moment, then smiled and patted her back.

"Thank you," Ning Fuyi said.

"No need to thank me—just treat me to roasted chicken." Nine Infants licked her lips.

"I'll treat you. Later I'll buy you all the roasted chicken in Point Star Town¹. You can't leave until you've finished it all." Ning Fuyi raised her eyebrows, then released her, her back straight as a pine or cypress.

"Now that we know the truth and our wishes have been fulfilled, where shall we go?" Nine Infants lazily crossed her arms.

"The Demon Realm." Ning Fuyi seemed to have regained her spirits, only the bit of red in her phoenix eyes revealing her previous grief. "But do you really want to come with me?"

"My current cultivation is suppressing your power. If you dissolve this blood contract with me, you could return to being a divine beast. Then you could live in seclusion in the mountains and forests, and Penglai probably couldn't do anything to you."

Nine Infants tapped her chin with her fingertip, looking thoughtful, then finally shook her head: "No. If we forcibly dissolve the blood contract, you'd lose a life if not half a life. I don't want to bear the name of devouring my master again."

"We qilin² don't seek great strength, only loyalty. Since you never abandoned me, I will never abandon you either."

Ning Fuyi took a deep breath and curved her lips: "Good."

The two of them locked the secret chamber again, put away the jade pendant, and stepped into the light outside the door. A rain cloud was blown away by the wind, revealing the orange-red sunset behind it and the brilliant evening glow beneath the setting sun.

Time passed so quickly—it had been almost a month since Chu Qingqiu left.

"In two days it will be the fifteenth of the eighth month³—a festival of reunion." Nine Infants looked up at the sky.

Yes, the Mid-Autumn Festival⁴. Ning Fuyi gazed far toward Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate.

"Tonight the bright moon is watched by all, but who knows whose home autumn thoughts will fall upon⁵." Those lively days at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate could probably only remain in dreams now.

"Let's go," she said.

The two had just reached the foot of the mountain when they saw Baili Shiqi running toward them, holding something in her arms, out of breath, her smile brilliant and dazzling in the evening glow.

"Sister Ning, Sister Nine Infants, look what I found!"

Ning Fuyi looked into her arms and opened her eyes wide in surprise. What she was struggling to hold was none other than Bai Lin⁶, who had somehow run to Purple Cloud Peak.

Seeing Ning Fuyi, Bai Lin also became excited, howling as it broke free from Baili Shiqi, raising its tail high as it ran toward Ning Fuyi, pushing its huge white tiger head into her embrace and circling around her.

"Bai Lin, you didn't die?" Ning Fuyi quickly crouched down.

Bai Lin made several whimpering sounds, its round paws bouncing in place.

Ning Fuyi touched its head and showed a gentle smile: "You ran to Purple Cloud Peak—you miss Chu Qingqiu, don't you?"

She sighed as she hugged the fluffy little white tiger into her arms, smelling the remaining gardenia fragrance on its fur.

"So do I."

Footnotes

¹ **Point Star Town** - A local town name where they plan to buy food

² **Qilin** - A Chinese mythical creature, often translated as "unicorn" but more accurately described as a chimeric beast with dragon-like features, symbolizing prosperity and serenity

³ **Fifteenth of the eighth month** - The date of the Mid-Autumn Festival in the Chinese lunar calendar

⁴ **Mid-Autumn Festival** - One of the most important festivals in Chinese culture, celebrating family reunion and the full moon

⁵ **"Tonight the bright moon..."** - A reference to a famous Tang dynasty poem by Wang Jian about the Mid-Autumn Festival and homesickness

⁶ **Bai Lin** - The white tiger companion that belongs to Chu Qingqiu